

Session 8: Signs and Wonders

Key Takeaways

- The plagues function symbolically as de-creation.
- The plagues point beyond themselves to later events in Exodus.
- The plagues serve as a warning and reminder of the disastrous non-life state outside the people's covenant relationship with Yahweh.

Literary Patterning in the Plague Narrative

Plague #	Forewarning	Timing	Command
1	Yes	"In morning"	Station self
2	Yes	None	Go to Pharaoh
3	None	None	None
4	Yes	"In morning"	Station self
5	Yes	None	Go to Pharaoh
6	None	None	None
7	Yes	"In morning"	Station self
8	Yes	None	Go to Pharaoh
9	None	None	None
10	Yes	None	None
Literary Pattern of the Plague Narrative. Created by Carmen Imes for BibleProject Classroom: Exodus Overview (2021).			

The Plagues as an Attack on Egypt's Gods?

The suggestion that each plague confronts a particular Egyptian god is an argument from silence. Many of the connections are quite weak. However, the plagues were clearly an affront to the order of Egyptian society and worship, especially to the very important concept of ma'at that governed Egyptian society. Ma'at is the ancient Egyptian concept of truth, balance, order, harmony, law, morality, and justice.

The Plagues as Natural Chain-Reaction Disasters?

The suggestion that the plagues were naturally occurring phenomena related to each other in a chain reaction is intriguing, but cannot account for all the plagues. Furthermore, it does not acknowledge the text's claim that each plague miraculously started and stopped at Moses' command.

The Plagues as Un-Creation

The literary design and repetition of themes suggests that the plagues are presented as a form of un-creation.

- Chaos in place of order
- Loss of dominion over creatures
- Boundaries erased between domains
- Creation no longer "good"

The Plagues as Signs of Judgment to Come

In "The Plagues as Ecological Signs of Historical Disaster" from *What Kind of God?*, Terence E. Fretheim identifies links between the plagues and the sea crossing in which the plagues "point beyond themselves toward a disastrous future" (Fretheim, 2015).

- Moses' staff "swallows" Egyptians' staffs, and Egyptians "swallowed" by the sea
- Water of the Nile turns to blood, and Egyptian armies killed in the sea
- Frogs "covered" the land, and the sea "covered" the Egyptians
- Dead frogs piled up, and dead Egyptians piled up
- Not one fly remained, and not one Egyptian remained
- Locusts driven into the sea, and Egyptians driven into the sea

The Plagues as Signs of Deliverance

Fretheim also notes that the narrator tells the story in such a way that we are invited to compare YHWH's treatment of the Egyptians and the Israelites (Fretheim, 2015).

- "They could not drink the water" ([Exod. 7:24; 15:23](#)).
- "Raining" hail vs. "raining" bread ([Exod. 9:18; 16:4](#)).
- "Came up and covered the land" ([Exod. 10:14-15; 16:13](#)).

The Plagues as a Warning

Deuteronomy 28:58-60 NIV

⁵⁸ If you do not carefully follow all the words of this law, which are written in this book, and do not revere this glorious and awesome name—the LORD your God— ⁵⁹ the LORD will send fearful plagues on you and your descendants, harsh and prolonged disasters, and severe and lingering illnesses. ⁶⁰ He will bring on you all the diseases of Egypt that you dreaded, and they will cling to you.

Reflection Question

Reflect on the plagues as a form of de-creation. How does this help you connect Exodus to Genesis? How does this set up what is yet to come in the rest of Exodus?